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Podcasts and Productivity: A Qualitative Uses and Gratifications Study

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Through analysis of five focus groups with people who “usually (more often than not) listened to at least one podcast episode a week” in the last two months, this uses and gratifications (U&G) study uncovers several prominent themes among podcast listener experiences. In an effort to integrate old and new media use typologies within U&G research, our results are presented in two parts: emerging typologies and expansions of existing typologies. The emerging section includes reasons for podcast displacement of other media, customizable experiences, and multitasking (which involves both temptation bundling and feeding the brain). The expansion builds on the existing typologies of companionship and interaction by analyzing avenues for parasocial relationship formation and identifying social opportunities as well as social frustrations surrounding podcasts. We ultimately conclude that podcasts offer an endless supply of engaging content that travels with listeners, allowing them to be “productive” in various physical and mind-expanding ways. The enjoyment is facilitated in part by forging connections with hosts and other listeners.

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We invite them into our kitchens while we cook, our cars while we commute, our offices while we work, and our pockets while we clean. A portmanteau of broadcasting and iPod (McClung & Johnson, 2010), podcasts are audio files that can be downloaded or streamed from a mobile device, usually at no direct cost to the user. This unique distribution avenue has enabled audio media innovation spanning topic, time, and structure. We consider it safe to say that podcasting will never be a peak mass medium, but, as Berry (2016) asserted, it appears to be entering a “period of credibility, stability and maturity” (p. 668). Indeed, statistics from the 2017 Edison Research study on podcasts revealed that 40% of the representative U.S. sample had listened to a podcast and 24% engaged in monthly listening, showing steady incremental growth in both categories over the past 5 years, from 29% and 14%, respectively (“Podcast Consumer,” 2017). Scholars have described podcast engagement as a “niche prosumer activity” (Menduni, 2007, p. 16), and noted that intense, loyal audience engagement is prized over size (Wade & Patterson, 2015). Podcasting seems to have found and stabilized its entertainment identity emphasizing a more personal and personalized experience.

Surveying the podcast literature, Markman (2015) highlighted the paucity of audience research, specifically on audience habits and motivations. This uses and gratifications (U&G) study works to close that gap in the literature by finding answers to this overarching research question: What specific U&G are listeners seeking and obtaining from podcasts? Answers to this question will help us more clearly see what this medium is offering to its increasing number of audience members, thus capturing emergent typologies for new media gratifications. The *process* of answering this question will also help us make methodological recommendations to other U&G researchers. Sundar and Limperos (2013) recommended “using the classic two-step [U&G] methodological approach of focus groups followed by surveys” (p. 507). The authors opined, however, that U&G researchers have tended to skip the first step, moving swiftly to survey designs that feature “instruments from studies of older media, modified slightly to suit the particular medium under investigation” (p. 507). The current research will hold heuristic value for scholars interested in conducting U&G-based survey research by providing a set of testable gratifications uniquely applicable to the podcast medium.

Through analysis of five focus groups with people who “usually (more often than not) listened to at least one podcast episode a week” in the 2 months prior to the focus group, this study uncovers several prominent themes among podcast listener experiences. Our results are presented in two parts—emerging U&G typologies and expansions of existing typologies—to offer a clear dialogue with the existing body of U&G literature. The emerging section includes reasons for displacement of other media, customizable experiences, and multitasking (which involves both temptation bundling and brain food). The expansion builds on the

existing typologies of companionship and interaction by analyzing avenues for parasocial relationship formation and identifying social opportunities as well as social frustrations surrounding podcasts. We ultimately conclude that podcasts offer an endless supply of engaging content that travels with listeners, allowing them to be “productive” in various physical and mind-expanding ways. The enjoyment is facilitated in part by forging connections with hosts and other listeners.

U&G LITERATURE REVIEW

U&G has been variously referred to as a theory, a perspective, and an approach to understanding people’s media use (Palmgreen, 1984). Here it is perhaps best thought of as “a way of thinking about and empirically testing individuals’ motives for media use” (Krcmar & Strizhakova, 2009, p. 64). The U&G tradition, regardless of the medium under investigation, is predicated on the assumption of active audience members who might use, interact with, and be impacted by that medium in various ways dependent, at least in part, upon the users’ individual differences (Sundar & Limperos, 2013). U&G, then, foregrounds a general conception of media users as discriminating, selective, rational, and in possession of enough self-awareness that they can identify the needs they seek from their media diet (Ruggiero, 2000). By their very nature, podcast users are noteworthy for “active decision making” as they “actively search for content” (Berry, 2016, p. 666) and interact with other users in a social multimedia environment (Markman, 2015); therefore, the assumption of an agentic, purposeful audience makes good theoretical sense in the current investigation.

Central to the U&G approach is the practice of categorizing various media user needs into one or a number of related typologies (Wang & Tchernev, 2012) that capture gratifications or “perceived fulfillment[s]” of those needs (Palmgreen, 1984). For example, Rubin (1984) divided the needs associated with TV viewing into either instrumental or ritualized. Rubin’s media use dichotomy has since been applied to media engagement behaviors such as talk radio listening (Rubin & Step, 2000), Internet use (Sundar & Limperos, 2013), and multitasking using various media (Wang & Tchernev, 2012). There is a long-standing practice dating back to the 1970s for U&G researchers to slot needs and gratifications into existing media use typologies, such as emotional, cognitive, social, habitual, or affective (see, e.g., Krcmar & Strizhakova, 2009; Schramm & Hartmann, 2008; Wang & Tchernev, 2012) and to integrate established U&G with emergent gratifications from newer media (e.g., Ferguson & Perse, 2000; Papacharissi & Rubin, 2000).

Ruggiero (2000) asserted that sorting media needs into typologies does not provide a “refined theoretical perspective,” but it does offer “a benchmark base

of data for other studies” (p. 12). On the other hand, Krcmar and Strizhakova (2009) cautioned that the proliferation of typologies without an associated attempt to integrate them “may do little to forward uses and gratifications as a meaningful approach” (p. 56). Sundar and Limperos (2013) argued that U&G researchers need to make space for more specific and emergent gratifications rather than relying only on established, generalized, and aggregated gratifications from older media if scholars want to improve their chances of accurately making sense of the role media use plays in today’s society. Ruggiero struck a productive middle ground by suggesting that U&G scholars take a hybrid approach by using theoretically relevant elements of existing gratification typologies while also making conceptual and empirical space for emergent needs associated with newer media practices. Our work aligns with this middle ground as it presents the analysis in a way to specifically highlight emergent gratifications and build out established typologies.

So how might we define and situate the podcast medium in the assemblage of media options that came before it and emerged along with it? Wade and Patterson (2015) clarified, “Podcasting is neither limited to nor defined by its technologies. Rather, it is a specific set of practices and cultural meanings that are entirely entwined with the technologies for its distribution, organization, and consumption” (pp. 221–222). Here, Wade and Patterson tap into one of the more difficult filigrees to untangle using U&G, namely, how a given technology’s affordances bump up against and comele with users’ preexisting individual differences as they use that technology within a particular sociocultural context. Eloquently explicating the antecedent, mediating, and consequent factors (Rubin, 1994) associated with early podcasting, Berry (2016) analyzed the iPod’s radio-related history, technological invitation to users (which includes the iPod and earbuds), and early commuter context, noting that these factors promoted “a privatized and personalized auditory experience” (p. 664).

Of course the gratifications associated with personalized podcast listening did not emerge out of thin air but rather developed in a complex process of displacement of and convergence with older media. From its roots in broadcast radio, to its immersive auditory older cousin audiobooks or books on tape (Markman, 2015), to the debt it owes to the mobile audio technologies like the Walkman, MP3 players, and smartphones (Berry, 2016; Wei, 2008; Zeng, 2011), it becomes clear that podcasts already have a foundation in U&G research.

Berry (2016) identified overlapping and distinctive U&G between radio and podcasting, arguing that listening to traditional radio is more of a linear process with messages moving mostly from sender to receiver, whereas podcast listening involves the choice to create a social yet personalized and customizable listening experience. Numerous other gratifications have been identified in the U&G literature related to podcasting and the technologies that afford them. These gratifications include sharing content through social media (Menduni, 2007),

time shifting (McClung & Johnson, 2010; Wade & Patterson, 2015), place shifting (Wade & Patterson, 2015; Wei, 2008), parasocial relationships with podcast hosts and characters (Hartmann, 2008), listener control and choice (which overlap with time and place shifting; Albarran et al., 2007), entertainment (McClung & Johnson, 2010), relaxation (Albarran et al., 2007), and passing the time (Albarran et al., 2007). Our study digs deeper into emergent U&G, many of which focus on the ability to enhance one's productivity by multitasking with the podcast medium. This multitasking theme represents an enhancement of the "control" U&G typology (of selecting the medium and content one wants, when one wants it). Users are not just controlling the listening experience: They are better able to control what *else* they are doing while they are listening.

METHODOLOGY

After securing Institutional Review Board approval from Merrimack College on March 1, 2017, a team of two professors and two directed study students conducted focus groups that spring. Participants were recruited through flyers posted on the campus of a midsize private New England college, e-mails to campus constituents, word of mouth, and the researchers' social media accounts.¹ Two groups were conducted in person on the college campus, and three groups were conducted virtually (Stancanelli, 2010) using Google Hangouts. All participants received \$10 Amazon gift cards.

The groups were segmented according to the recruitment method and the recruiter. For example, the two students primarily recruited participants from campus for in-person focus groups held in a library meeting room. Almost all of their participants ($N = 9$) were students, staff, or faculty. The focus groups conducted online ($N = 14$) comprised the two professors' personal contacts, social media connections, and snowball sampling (e.g., some participants invited a friend or coworker). The online focus groups tended to attract more avid podcast listeners who were eager to speak with others about their experiences, whereas the face-to-face participants tended to be more casual listeners. The researchers intentionally avoided a student-only sample and a sample recruited through podcast fan communities. The convenience sample and the online focus groups were used in an effort to maximize geographic and age diversity, as well as capture a wide variety of listening preferences and purposes.

After reviewing and signing consent forms (in person or through e-mail), participants filled out a brief questionnaire that asked about demographics, as well as podcast listening information: how, how much, and what podcasts they

¹ Moderators were acquainted with some of the participants, but no one moderated a focus group consisting of family members or colleagues.

listened to. The semistructured focus groups were based on 10 question areas covering topics such as how participants got started listening to podcasts, the conditions under which they listened, what entertainment they used before podcasts were available, what they liked about their favorite podcasts, and what they looked for in a host.² Each moderator transcribed her or his own focus group(s).

Twenty-three participants were split among the five focus groups (ranging from three to six participants each). Recognizing the importance of balancing a collection of diverse voices and enough “air time” for all participants (Fabiano & Lederman, 2002), the researchers purposely aimed for smaller focus groups. Our primary concern was the online focus groups in which nonverbal cues indicating that one is ready to speak (e.g., shifting in one’s seat, clearing one’s throat) would be tougher to detect, thus adding more dead time and less time for conversation. In the beginning of the online focus groups, participants tended to go in order of left to right (in terms of whose face appeared where on the video conference screen). As the groups learned first names and seemed to feel more comfortable, participants began chiming in whenever they wanted to build on someone’s statement or offer an alternative view. The nature of the dialogue indicated that the groups were indeed “fostering honesty rather than socially desirable responses” (Lederman, 1990, p. 119).

Participants included 14 women and nine men. The vast majority self-identified as Caucasian. One participant identified as Chinese and one as Asian American. The age range of participants was 19 to 55, with an average of 33.7. The study population had higher educational attainment than the general population: graduate degree ($n = 10$), bachelor’s degree ($n = 7$), some college ($n = 4$), high school degree or equivalent ($n = 1$).³ One participant chose not to answer this question. In terms of their listening behaviors captured in our prefocus group survey, we found that participants listened to podcasts for a range of 15 to 4,000 minutes per week.⁴ Our second highest number of minutes per week was 1,500. Removing the 4,000-minute outlier, participants listened an average of 346 minutes per week. Seventeen participants listened through their iPhone and/or the Overcast application. Ten noted that they listened through their computer.⁵

² The full schedule of focus group questions is available from the first author.

³ Our demographic form did not ask about occupations, but several participants mentioned their work through the course of their focus group. Our participants came from the fields of education, entertainment, law, and construction, among others.

⁴ The participant who reported listening for 4,000 minutes was asked if that total was accurate and responded “seriously.” Although this is a notable outlier, ideas expressed by this person that are included in this article always had support from two or three other focus group participants (not necessarily in the same group), so we consider the data from that person to be instructive.

⁵ The numbers add up to more than 23 because some participants listed multiple ways they listened.

The study's single-spaced transcripts collectively took up 62 pages. The transcripts were analyzed using grounded theory. Following grounded theory procedure (Corbin & Strauss, 2015), the first author read through all transcripts carefully without taking notes, took notes during a second reading, and created a transcript memo on a third reading that listed out all possible themes (46 total). The most notable themes were selected based on their frequency of mention and the level of detail focus group participants provided about the theme. At that point, the second author added new support to the memo and weighed in on what themes should be covered in the analysis. In the end, we settled on five themes to present a full picture of the U&G participants found in podcasts: reasons for media displacement, customizable experiences, multitasking (with "temptation bundling" and "feed the brain" as gratification subthemes), parasocial relationship pathways, and social opportunities/frustrations. The multitasking section, covered in the middle of the analysis, represents what we see as the most unique gratification focus group participants were taking from podcast listening.

ANALYSIS

To both embed our findings in previous U&G typologies and to make space for emergent findings, the analysis is organized into two main sections: (a) emergent gratifications and (b) expansions of established gratifications. Our findings in the first theme—media displacement—illustrate the interaction between technological affordances and listener agency (see, e.g., Sundar, 2008). The media displacement theme implicitly taps into the changing relevance and availability of particular typologies, along with the expected gratifications those affordances may nurture. Our second major section—expansions on previously established gratifications—helps put our findings in dialogue with existing typologies, demonstrating deeper understanding of parasocial relationship formation and the social opportunities/frustrations associated with podcast listening.

EMERGENT GRATIFICATIONS

Media Displacement: Fresh and Mobile

Focus group participants' descriptions of their pathways to podcasts—and the media they transitioned from—help us understand how podcasts offered emergent (or resurrected) U&G in particular contexts. Podcasts were most commonly replacements for radio/music and television. They seemed to be most similar to (and, for some participants, on a continued rotation with) audiobooks. Marian (White woman, 37) saw differences between contemporary radio and podcasts but similarities to

radio as it once was, noting that podcasts hearken “back to like old-timey radio. So that’s part of what appeals to me about it is listening to stories on the radio.” Studying radio U&G in the medium’s golden age, Herzog (1944) observed that radio storytelling enabled listeners to “fill in gaps of their own life” (p. 24). Facing television competition, radio shifted focus from stories to music, but it seems that people are craving audio raconteurs once again. Jessica (White woman, 30) listened to audiobooks for at least 5 years before participating in the focus group. She found audiobooks and podcasts to offer a similar experience, stating, “I’ve always been attuned to storytelling formats. Podcasts were just newer.”

“Boring” and “repetitive” were the most prevalent criticisms of contemporary radio and music. Ryan (Asian American man, 35) recalled turning to podcasts in 2009 or 2010 because he “was just kind of bored at work” and tired of “the same music over and over.” Lily (White woman, 42) did not like the thought of going back to listening to the radio once she became a podcast convert because “I’d probably be pushing the buttons a lot because there’s nothing on that I would want to hear.” Even switching to satellite radio was not enough to satiate Dan’s appetite for new content. Dan (White man, 55) was an early adopter of satellite radio and felt it “was starting to get a little played, a little boring” when he decided to switch over to podcasts. Both Lily’s and Dan’s preferences and expected gratifications changed along with audio media evolutions.

In contrast to “boring” radio, podcasts were seen as fresher, more unique, and more engaging in part because of their rapidly expanding content. Wendy (White woman, 35) agreed with Ryan’s assessment of music being the “same stuff over and over” and appreciated podcasts as part of her steady media diet because “there’s always something new.” The extensive catalogs of old podcasts and newly released episodes from various genres enable listeners to perpetually find something unique at their leisure. Jeff (White man, 39) noted that the wide availability of different podcasts led him to crave fresh content, a relatively permanent shift in his listening preferences: “I like listening to shows I’ve never heard before. [Listening to podcasts] has changed what I want.” Jeff’s language about a shift in what he wants relates to Sundar and Limperos (2013) observation that an emergent gratification (in this case, craving unique and nonrepetitive content) may become a more stable gratification. This gratification may even transcend the medium.

Whereas radio was too boring and repetitive, television was engaging—but not mobile enough. Despite being able to watch television content on portable screens, the need to view the screen was too restrictive for our podcast listeners. This theme really took off in one focus group, starting with Alan (White man, 39):

I used to sit and watch TV constantly and that’s a lot harder now with the family growing. ... So there’s always something to do at the house, and I can get it done more easily if I’m listening to a podcast. And I can’t get it done at all if I’m trying to watch TV.

A smartphone playing a podcast can be tucked into one's pocket as one moves about the house putting away laundry, making lunches, cleaning, or completing other tasks. Joel (White man, 50) concurred with Alan, preferring podcasts because "you're up and mobile. You're not locked into being in front of a TV, and you can, you know, do whatever you gotta do."

We find a contradictory pair of themes under the media displacement umbrella: Podcasts can facilitate both productivity and relaxation. Gwen, Peg, and Colin would listen before bedtime to unwind. Gwen (White woman, 44) switched away from watching TV in the evening and instead used podcasts "to decompress in bed." Peg (White woman, 26) thought that podcasts were an excellent "TV replacement, especially for maybe like later at night, trying to avoid like having screens on or around." For Colin (Chinese man, 25), podcasts afforded an unusual combination of stimulation and relaxation: "It's like my bedtime story. ... If I can just close my eyes, I can just fall asleep while still getting some information." The auditory, rather than visual, stimulation offered Colin a chance to both learn something and pave the way for sleep.

Customizable Experience

Offering consumers an easily customized experience is a burgeoning media trend: from search engine alerts, to on demand content, to streaming services. Albarran et al. (2007) applied the term "demassification" to describe the most recent era in audio entertainment in which users are asserting power over the medium to select particular content at particular times. Peg (White woman, 26) described the agentic appeal of podcast listening this way: "I think I might be like outing myself as a millennial but the best thing about podcasts for me is that I get to choose what I listen to when I listen to it and how I listen to it." Colin (Chinese man, 25), another millennial, was also emphatic when praising the personalized experience: "It's anti-TV programming where somebody is ... telling you you're going to watch *CSI* on Thursdays. ... I'm like, 'What kind of mood am I in? I'm going to listen to this.'" He later summed it up as, "I curate my own experience." Both Wendy (White woman, 35) and Marian (White woman, 37) appreciated podcasts because you can just "skip around" episode to episode.

Jeff's (White man, 39) explanation for the appeal of customization references not just personal enjoyment but efficiency: You have "limited time in your day, limited time in your in your, you know, life, and you can only experience so many things. So I think it's a good opportunity to listen to what you really want to listen to." Creating one's own listening experience from all of the available episodes dovetails with multitasking and a desire for efficiency. In various ways, podcasts allow listeners to squeeze the most out of every moment.

Multitasking

We define multitasking simply as listening to podcasts and engaging in at least one more activity at the same time (see also Jeong & Fishbein, 2007; Wang & Tchernev, 2012). Multitasking can be motivated by several factors, including perceived efficiency, enjoyment, and habit (Hwang, Kim, & Jeong, 2014). This theme relates to Lull's (1980) classification of television as an environmental resource, a companion—for accomplishing things like chores. As this theme demonstrates, however, podcasts are seen as a *better* companion than television for many tasks.

Presenting our results *Family Feud* style reveals that commuting or driving was the most popular activity to pair with podcast listening ($n = 15$), followed by doing chores ($n = 12$), bathing ($n = 5$), working ($n = 4$), dog walking ($n = 4$), getting ready for the day ($n = 3$), and using social media ($n = 3$).⁶ Commuting was not only the most popular activity to go with podcasts, it was often what drove people to podcasts.⁷ Wendy (White woman, 35), one of our earliest adopters, said she “started listening in 2009 on my way to and from my first job out of school,” which involved “an hour train ride.” Peg (White woman, 26) used *This American Life* “to kind of break up my commute because I was biking about 12 miles a day and I needed something to do with my time.” Peg was already doing several things with her time—traveling to work and exercising—but she wanted further stimulation and enrichment.

This idea of making better use of one's time (through multitasking) was quite common in interviewees' descriptions of their behaviors. Joel's (White man, 50) dialogue captures that sentiment: “I have an hour commute to work so ... I'll listen to a podcast and try to educate myself in some way or whatever, make it more productive than just sitting in traffic.” The word “productive” was a common descriptor of the experience of multitasking with podcasts. Listening was a way to expand one's world while physically doing something else. When asking friends for podcast recommendations, Rachel (White woman, 37) phrased it this way: “What should I do with my ears while I'm driving?”

And what do you do once you have arrived at work? Listen to more podcasts was the answer for some. Three of four interviewees who specifically mentioned listening at work noted an affinity for “background noise.” For example, Ryan (Asian American man, 35) stated, “If I'm at work, I also like to have noise in the background so sometimes I'll listen there as well.” Ambivalent attitudes emerged in this thread. Wendy (White woman, 35) described her habits this way: “In the

⁶ Listening to audio media while traveling was also the most common form of multitasking in Jeong and Fishbein's (2007) study of adolescent multitasking.

⁷ Bluetooth connectivity between vehicles and mobile phones has undoubtedly made it easier to listen and self-program while commuting.

morning from about 7 to 12 I like to have like background noise [at work] so now I just listen pretty much—my boss probably wouldn't be happy to hear—but I listen pretty much all morning." Gwen (White woman, 44) noted that she listens "kind of a lot" and offered, "I will confess that now ... I will play podcasts in my office at work when I'm working. I like to have background noise. And I can kind of attend to two things at once." Wendy was concerned about how her podcast listening would look to her boss—perhaps like she was not paying enough attention to her work tasks. And Gwen prefaced her work habits with the phrase "I will confess," as if listening to podcasts at work was a secret to keep. Studies have indeed demonstrated that multitasking can yield increased emotional gratifications but hinder cognitive processing (Voorveld, 2011; Wang & Tchernev, 2012). Bosses of podcast listeners may therefore have happier yet less cognitively engaged employees.

The previous two paragraphs offer unique looks at arousal regulation. Whereas mood management theory explains how individuals optimize affect and arousal (Zillmann, 1988) and mood adjustment accounts for how people regulate affect and arousal in preparation for upcoming tasks (Knobloch, 2003), the regulation taking place here occurs *simultaneously* with the multitasking activity. We call this multitasking mood management "mood balancing" because the nature of the podcast is complementary to the nature of the work. For folks doing boring tasks, the podcast was an engaging arousal boost. For those at work who perhaps liked background noise but still needed mental space to think, the podcast was more of an arousal moderator.

As a counterpoint to the multitasking section, it is imperative to note that some interviewees stated that they did not multitask while listening to some or all podcasts. Grace (White woman, 21) commonly multitasked, but it was not her only way to listen. She recalled, "There are times when I will sit down and focus strictly on the podcast." Some interviewees were highly focused on a specific type of podcast, such as Jessica (White woman, 30), who noted that if it is a "hard reporting" podcast, "that's definitely much more of like a just listening kind of thing" compared to a "junk foody" type of podcast where you "don't really have to pay that close of attention." Podcasts, like many other forms of entertainment, are flexible and able to be used for deep dive into a story or background noise that can be easily tuned in or out.

Temptation Bundling. Multitasking describes a behavior that comes with several gratifications: feelings of productivity, learning something new, and passing the time. Feelings of productivity can spring from (a) getting a work or household task accomplished and/or (b) learning or expanding one's world through a podcast. We got a taste of this theme when focus group participants compared podcasts to other media. As we develop the multitasking theme more thoroughly here, we see that podcast listening should be considered a form of temptation

bundling. Temptation bundling, a concept that the first author heard about through the *Freakonomics* podcast, involves coupling “instantly gratifying ‘want’ activities” with engagement in a ‘should’ behavior” that is not immediately gratifying and requires willpower to complete (Milkman, Minson, & Volpp, 2014, pp. 283–284).⁸ If you have to do something mundane, distasteful, or boring, make it more enjoyable by putting on an engaging story or learning something new about the world. This temptation bundling offers what we see as bundled or tandem gratifications.

Ryan (Asian American man, 35) explained the appeal of multitasking when doing something mundane this way: “It kind of just makes me feel like I’m not doing what it is I’m doing.” This distraction is particularly welcome when one is engaged in an unpleasant task. Rachel’s (White woman, 37) example highlights this point: “Head lice has been going through my daughter’s classroom. So the hour that we sit combing and picking, she gets to choose her podcasts and that makes it slightly more bearable.” Jessica (White woman, 30), who listened while shoveling snow, used similar wording, saying that podcasts “made [shovel-ing] more bearable, so like the couple of times when I didn’t [listen to podcasts] it was definitely like, ‘I’m never gonna be done.’” Podcasts cannot just help a person get started on a boring or mundane task, they can also help motivate one to see the task through and make time feel like it is passing more quickly. Podcast listening could therefore be seen as a high-tech version of whistling while you work.

Listening to storytelling podcasts in particular seemed to help some participants lose track of time. Jenny (White woman, 36) offered support for the temporal warp speed, explaining, “I think the other reason why I prefer [podcasts] to listening to music is like the time goes by quicker when I’m listening to a story.” Although the researchers did not focus on storytelling, quantitative findings by Chinchanchokchai, Duff, and Sar (2015) affirmed that media multitaskers perceive time as passing more quickly and experience more enjoyment than those only engaged in one task. Dan (White man, 55) described his love for stories at several points in the focus group, noting that National Public Radio’s *StoryCorp* was what initially drove him to download podcasts. He knew he found a great story if this happened: “I won’t be able to get anything else done until I hear the end of the podcast. And so I will sit in my car, in front of my house just so I’ll be able to listen to it.” Several of Dan’s fellow focus group members nodded in agreement. Lily (White woman, 42) from a different group stated, “Sometimes I’ll just drive out of my way so I can have more time to listen.” Even if podcast listening’s boring multitasking companion (e.g., commuting) ceased, the podcast listening would often continue.

⁸ The initial temptation bundling study was conducted using “tempting audiobooks” to motivate participants’ gym use. It should be noted that when asked to compare media, many participants considered audiobooks to be the most similar to podcasts.

Feed the Brain. Peg (White woman, 26) bridged the two “productivity” gratifications with her statement:

When I’m doing something pretty mundane like driving or cleaning and I’m, you know, bored, it kind of like makes me feel I’m being productive and learning something when I also have to do something I maybe don’t want to do.

Entertainment was an implicit part of many focus group participants’ explanations of why they enjoy podcasts; more specifically, however, education or learning something new (components of the information U&G typology; Rubin, 1983) emerged as primary gratifications. Her alternative to listening to podcasts was watching “crap TV” on Netflix, so Rachel (White woman, 37) preferred podcasts because they “felt a little more nutritive for my brain.” Rachel concisely explained that listening to podcasts “was definitely a way of doing something for my brain while my hands were busy.” Whether in the car, in the home, or in the office, podcasts, Joel (White man, 50) said, “open up my world.”

Not only did podcast listeners enjoy their ability to learn something through podcasts, a few actually felt as if they were not using their time properly if multitasking was unavailable. Elizabeth and Colin expressed similar sentiments:

Elizabeth (White woman, 54): “If my phone’s dead or charging or something I feel like, ‘Ugh, waste of time’ when I could be listening while I’m folding laundry or whatever.”

Colin (Chinese man, 25): “If I didn’t have podcasts to listen to or something to listen to during the time of a regular chore ... I would feel like I’m *wasting* my time. I *selectively* listen to podcasts that I believe will—this is going to sound sentimental—nourish my brain.”

Not having a podcast to listen to made Elizabeth and Colin feel as if they were missing out on an opportunity—the opportunity to learn something new or enjoy their boring tasks.

EXPANSIONS OF ESTABLISHED GRATIFICATIONS

Pathways to Parasocial Relationships

Many participants described their relationships with podcast hosts using language that signified parasocial relationships, which are defined as the “seeming face-to-face relationship” between audience member and performer (Horton & Wohl, 1979, p. 32). Discussing *Pop Culture Happy Hour*, Jenny (White woman,

36) said, “I love the people. I want to be best friends with them all.” Jeff (White man, 39) considered his relationships with hosts to be like a “friendship” or “fondness.” Peg (White woman, 26) went as far as saying, “Ira Glass feels like one of my friends.” Addressing the mostly one-directional nature of parasocial relationships, Jessica (White woman, 30) described podcast hosts as “friends that don’t know they’re my friends.” Parasocial relationships were a driving force in many interviewees’ decisions about what to listen to. Rebecca (White woman, 32) stated, “Most of the podcasts I listen to are actually the ones that have hosts where I feel like I could be friends with them in real life.”

Interviewees were able to provide not just evidence of parasocial relationships but explanations about why they formed those relationships, the latter of which expands on the companionship U&G typology. This typology covers a sense of being around (mediated) others (see, e.g., Papacharissi & Mendelson, 2007; Rubin, 1983). Media companionship can include parasocial relationships, loneliness mitigation, or other feelings of sociability. The most common themes were the frequency or regularity of contact, opportunities to interact with hosts through social media or other avenues (thus creating the possibility for a two-way relationship), the conversational quality of the podcast, similarities between listener and host, and host sharing of personal information.

Jeff (White man, 39) was fond of Roman Mars, host of *99% Invisible*, “because of the frequency in which I listen to [the show].” Several interviewees were able to increase their exposure to hosts by using social media—and sometimes have a true interaction. Wendy (White woman, 35) followed “pretty much all” of the podcast hosts she listened to on Twitter and sent story ideas to some. Grace (White woman, 21) often multitasked by looking at Twitter to see other listeners’ podcast reactions and to tweet at hosts. She enthusiastically admitted, “Sometimes I hope that they’ll even read my tweet!” This mechanism for listener to host backchanneling was important to Rachel (White woman, 37), who e-mailed her focus group moderator about it on April 12, 2017: “No other medium I consume has a mechanism for listeners to comment directly and/or direct the content. ... Somehow the podcast feels more intimate, more personal for this solicitousness.” This solicitousness offers the mutualistic benefits of drawing listeners further into the podcast world, thereby encouraging loyalty and a more enjoyable, engaging experience.

Having several hosts or panelists weigh in on a topic helped some listeners feel like there was a space for them in the conversation. Ryan (Asian American man, 35) explained it this way: “If you’re just listening to one person it feels as if you’re being talked to as opposed to those types of [podcast] conversations. ... I almost feel a little bit like I’m a part of it in a way.” The dialogic nature of some podcasts, including the sports ones Ryan listened to, helped to invite listeners in with their room for dis/agreement and space for multiple voices. Jenny (White woman, 36) stated that *Pop Culture Happy Hour* “feels like the kind of

conversation I would want to have with a group of my friends,” and she reacted accordingly, “pretend[ing] to be part of that conversation” and sometimes talking to the hosts “even though I’m in my car and they can’t hear me.” This type of participatory response is a sign of Jenny deriving enjoyment from the seemingly interactive nature of the program.

Host sharing of personal information sometimes cultivated this sense of intimacy. There was an element of uncertainty reduction in this exchange (see also Rubin & Step, 2000). Elizabeth (White woman, 54), a *West Wing Weekly* fan, noted that the hosts “talk a lot about different things in their personal lives so I do feel like I have a sense of their personality as distinct from the content of the podcast.” Grace (White woman, 21) listened to *Always Open*, a podcast that bills itself as a “late-night chat” with friends. She mentioned that the hosts “share about things that are personal like the first time they had sex. ... These personal stories aren’t things that people just share unless you really get to know them. ... It forces you to feel close.” Hearing a host’s personal experiences *and* having experiences in common can enhance those feeling of connectedness. Rebecca (White woman, 32) stated that listening to podcasts “makes me feel less alone, knowing that other people have these experiences or are going through similar struggles.” The personal topics of conversation, the dialogue among hosts (or among hosts and guests), and commonalities between host and listener can all present invitations for intimacy.

Surprisingly, these host connections were powerful enough to keep some interviewees listening to new episodes—even if the topic was not appealing. Alan (White man, 39) mentioned Lauren Spohrer from *Criminal* as a favorite. He noted there’s “something about her voice and her delivery. ... I’m just always excited when it comes on, even if I don’t care about the topic.” Joel (White man, 50) admitted to the same practice, remarking, “I’ll sit through podcasts that I’m not as interested in or something, the subject matter that might not be as interesting, just because I like the host.” Jessica (White woman, 30) cited *Last Podcast on the Left* as an example in which she might not be “terribly interested” in a given episode topic but she “like[s] the people enough to just stick with it anyway.” This theme suggests a host sincerity/listener loyalty connection that is consonant with what Horton and Wohl (1979) posited in their initial work on parasocial relationships.

Social Gratifications/Frustrations

Listening to podcasts was often described as an individualized experience, but one that was enveloped in social practices, such as recommending podcast listening to others, recommending specific podcasts or episodes, or discussing the content of an episode. Because communication with others often preceded and followed podcast listening, it has some commonalities with the social

interaction U&G typology (see, e.g., Papacharissi & Mendelson, 2007).⁹ The multitasking aspect of podcast listening often contributed to the solo nature of the experience: Many focus group participants were listening while commuting, cooking, and cleaning—activities that are often completed alone. It was also difficult for some to coordinate tastes with others. Ryan (Asian American man, 35) noted simply, “If my wife is with me [while driving], we always listen to music because we don’t really share the same interests in terms of podcasts.” Gwen (White woman, 44) recounted a longer struggle with her wife that began with talk radio, which Gwen “loves” and her wife “hates”: “I’ll find myself listening to things and I’ll say, ‘Oh my gosh, there’s this really great podcast and you have to listen.’ ... And she’ll be like ‘No, I’m not doing this.’” Perhaps the experience of an intimate podcast is all one needs to feel connected. Rebecca (White woman, 32) enjoyed listening to podcasts alone in part because “it fills up the empty space with something new ... something more ... emotional? It gives me more emotional and intellectual fulfillment.”

Recommendations from others were often precursors to this solo media engagement experience. Both Marian (White woman, 37) and Lily (White woman, 42) had robust recommendation exchanges with their work colleagues. Marian recommended several titles through her weekly work newsletter. Lily described a workplace social life in which podcasts were a common topic of conversation: “We talk about the content. We recommend to each other because we know [what] we all like. We talk about how fun it would be to do a podcast.” For Jenny (White woman, 36), it took unique content to get podcast-related conversations going: “*Serial* was probably the big one that got me started like actually having conversations with people about podcasts.” Laura (White woman, 35), too, was engaged in discussions about and even had a listening party for *Serial* in which her group of friends “just hung around the iPhone and listened to [a final *Serial* episode] while we ate pizza.” Laura’s *Serial* group reactivated to recommend and discuss *S-Town*.

Despite these examples of recommendations and discussions, several podcast listeners expressed confusion or frustration regarding others’ unwillingness to listen to podcasts or to understand the medium. Peg (White woman, 26) explained, “Something that I find really interesting is the kind of general hesitancy around downloading the app and figuring out how to get to podcasts and start listening to them.” Wendy (White woman, 35) found it frustrating that her parents who are avid National Public Radio listeners would not listen to podcasts: “I’ve even, I’ve downloaded [podcast episodes] for my mom on her phone, and they just sit there. Like she would love *S-Town* if she listened to it, but she just can’t seem to get the idea of it somehow.” Because her high school

⁹ Lull (1980) labeled these “relational” gratifications.

journalism students were not listening to podcasts, Jenny (White woman, 36) had trouble interesting them in the production side of things, noting that “no one really seemed to get that all into” a podcast section for their online newspaper. In sum, the social U&G typology for podcasts harbors notable contradictions. Podcast listening is often a solo experience, but one that is often driven by and drives social interactions. This social impetus is often thwarted by others’ lack of knowledge about what podcasts are and their reluctance to “try a pod.”

CONCLUSIONS

This qualitative study of regular podcast listeners reveals several emergent U&G. First, podcast listening supplanted radio listening and television viewing for many of our focus group participants. The explanations for the shift implicitly clarify podcast gratifications. Podcast listening won out over radio because of podcasts’ engaging, always changing content. Listening was preferable to television viewing in many in-home situations because podcasts do not command the visual sense, and they can be listened to on portable devices, thus enabling people to accomplish housework and other tasks. The television replacement thread previews our most robust theme of multitasking. Multitasking is broken into two parts that capture temptation bundling (accomplishing boring or mundane tasks by enjoying podcasts in tandem) and feeding one’s brain by listening while doing something mindless. In terms of expanding existing gratifications, focus group participants clarified various avenues of parasocial relationship development, including a conversational feel to the podcast, frequency of listening, host sharing of personal information, similarities with hosts, and backchanneling options. Finally, the social nature of podcast listening presented contradictions that expand the preestablished social U&G typology: Because the medium is relatively new, it created robust niche groups of listeners but also left behind many who were not willing to give it a try. Put differently, the social theme is a typology that captures U&G *and* frustrations about actualized or missed social opportunities.

The inductive, qualitative methodology for this study has promoted U&G typology innovation. A quantitative survey using established or modified typologies may not have uncovered the nuance to multitasking behaviors, the causes ascribed to parasocial relationship formation, or ambivalence surrounding the social aspects of podcast listening. The focus group participants led the researchers there. In highlighting some gratifications, podcast listeners have forsaken others. A 2010 podcast U&G study by McClung and Johnson noted the importance of library building, which no longer seems relevant. The ubiquity and relatively low cost of streaming services for music, television, and even films has made library building an outdated practice. Many of our focus group participants

did not want to save or even manage their content, such as Lily (White woman, 42), who had to delete episodes, “otherwise I get super overwhelmed.” With regard to entertainment gratifications, we were able to drill into more specific benefits (e.g., portable entertainment, immersive storytelling, and roundtable discussions that invite listeners in) from our focus group conversations. These findings suggest that podcasts are appealing primarily because they help listeners learn more and do more.

Although the current study has heuristic utility, it was not without its methodological limitations. First, the focus groups were limited in both size and diversity, especially in terms of respondents’ race or ethnicity as well as their relatively high level of educational attainment. We also did not assess our participants’ socioeconomic class or political leanings. These sampling weaknesses can inform suggestions for other research. Future podcast studies should explore potential differences among gratifications sought and obtained by people from racially and ethnically diverse backgrounds, various educational attainment levels, political leanings, and socioeconomic classes. Second, use of both face-to-face and virtual focus groups perhaps means that the nature, flow, and tone of the discourse shifted as the contexts of those discussions shifted (from mediated to nonmediated). Despite intentionally keeping the focus groups relatively small and purposefully providing convenient ways for our respondents to participate, the qualitative nature of this work along with the methodological decisions for recruitment and facilitation do ultimately limit the generalizability of the current findings.

The findings and processes from this research can be used to make methodological recommendations for other U&G studies. Qualitative research is the first step in the classic two-step mixed method many recommend for U&G studies (e.g., Leung & Zhang, 2016; Ruggiero, 2000; Sundar & Limperos, 2013).¹⁰ Specifically asking focus group participants about media displacement in a schedule of questions can help position the medium in question relative to existing typologies from other media. Furthermore, analyzing the qualitative data in a way that prioritizes emergent and expanded gratifications is warranted. Our initial grounded theory analysis yielded 46 themes, too many to be reported on in one traditional-length manuscript. The story we chose to tell from these data was grounded in the frequency and depth of mentions but also in U&G innovation: What newer, prominent gratifications emerged? How do these improve our understanding of either podcast listening or gratification typologies more generally?

The current findings also offer useful information for media practitioners interested in expanding their podcast listenership. Most broadly, podcasts firmly signal our shift from a push to a pull media landscape wherein the consumer can

¹⁰ For example, Rubin (1981) used a hybrid qualitative and quantitative method to assess scale construct validity and confirm the reliability of quantitative self-reports.

draw upon the customizable, agentic appeal of podcasts to actively assemble their own listening experience around the realities of daily life. Media practitioners, then, should concentrate on producing nimble and segmented audio content that can be consumed on multiple media platforms. Despite shifting from a push to a pull model, the classic transportational qualities of immersive narratives and engaging edutainment that have been the hallmark of television, radio and film for decades still resonate in the mobile and social world of podcasts.

Another primary implication of these findings is the recognition of *divergent* gratifications in the new media sphere: those that command attention and those that release attention. New developments in media, such as virtual reality, are focused on engaging the senses in new and absorbing ways. Podcasts, however, have carved out a niche (or, one might say, recarved an old radio niche) by being passive and not asking much of listeners. What we see in the robust multitasking theme is a collection of media gratifications (entertainment, information, engaging storytelling) stacked on a nonmedia gratification (accomplishing physical or mental work). That stacking is enabled by podcasts being content to stay in the background. One needs to just lend an ear to receive knowledge, news, and insight into the human condition from podcasts. Our findings clarify what podcasts ask of listeners (very little attention in some cases), what it allows listeners to do (multitask, be on the move, feel connected to others), and what it encourages listeners to do (check off that to-do list through temptation bundling, keep expanding their minds). We can thus see that key strengths of the podcast medium are allowing its promotion of enhanced agency within the medium and enhanced activity external to the act of listening. This new niche, although passive in terms of sensory use, allows listeners to actively control their content, to be their own programmers and brain feeders.

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